

Lesson 03:

Introduction & Spiritual Arguments

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From the positions of celestial bodies to atomic particles, the world around us is in perfect harmony. If the Creator of the universe can arrange them in order, would He not order His own speech? Dr. Hamiduddin Farahi's theory shows how reflecting on our surroundings will bring us to the conclusion that the Quran is heavenly ordered, and how the lack of reflection can lead to a spiritual crisis.

- Hamiduddin Farahi, a great scholar of the 20th century, wrote a book about coherence in the Quran: دلائل النظام « *Evidence of Coherence* ».
- He wrote a commentary on the Quran based on his theory of how the Quran is organized, but he only completed nine surahs before he passed away.
- He predominantly wrote in Arabic and 45 of his manuscripts that have been found.
- Ustadh Nouman met a Sudanese brother in Malaysia who was working on a PhD thesis on Farahi, in Jordan. He went to India and collected as many manuscripts as he could. He found some written in Persian and in Hebrew as well as one or two papers in English.
- Ustadh Nouman met Dr. Akram Nadwi in Oxford, who gave him a book by Farahi about the identity of the son who was meant to be slaughtered by Prophet Ibrahim (PBUH). Was it Ismail or Ishaq?
- Muslims believe it is Ismail, but the majority of Jews and Christians believe it is Ishaq.
- The Christian and the Jewish conviction that it was Ishaq affirms their belief that because he was the son chosen for sacrifice, then his lineage was blessed, while the other son and his lineage were cursed. This is how they built the myth that Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is a descendent of the cursed lineage, so this religion (Islam) is from the devil.
- Dr. Hamiduddin Farahi wrote this book in three parts:

Part 1: The story of the sacrifice in the Hebrew bible, with the Hebrew citation and linguistic analysis proving that it took place in Mecca and that it was Ismail (PBUH). He proves that many details were purposely changed such as the claim that the sacrifice happened near the temple of Solomon, who in fact came many generations later. He also points out that in the Hebrew bible, the incident took place in a city called Sakka, "full of black rocks in a desert with a spring of water. This cannot possibly be Jerusalem which was lush and where the Temple of Solomon was built much later.

Part 2: Farahi collected papers from scholars of the Jewish tradition and the Muslim tradition, proving that many of them actually believed that Ismail (PBUH) was the son intended for sacrifice.

Part 3: The evidence in the Quran

This includes Farahi's analysis of the story of Ibrahim (PBUH) and the sacrifice of his son Ismail (PBUH) in the Quran itself.

Farahi wrote a book about the coherence of the Quran, *دلائل النظام* whose introduction Ustadh Nouman often cites at the beginning of his Friday sermons in Arabic. In this introduction, he praises Allah in a way that is related to the subject he is dealing with, in this case, focusing on evidence of absolute order in the universe:

"Praise and Gratitude belongs to Allah the one who crafts creation in the most perfect order and the most beautiful upright form. The One who places things in the most appropriate way in the most appropriate of all places. And I send salutations upon the one (PBUH) who was aided with the most eloquent of all speech. The speech and the Prophet (PBUH) that was so distinct like the full moon that appears in the middle of the night for the Guidance of all of creation. And I send prayers and salutations on his family and his noble companions, for as long as there are days and nights. And this is a book that we dedicated to sequence on the Quran."

- Farahi's spiritual argument is captured in the way he praised Allah.

*"The beginnings of guidance have to do with how advanced human beings are and the special qualities human beings have. Allah guides human beings differently than He guides cows and birds, and bees and trees. The most predominant features of how we receive guidance is the ability to clearly communicate: *البيان*"*

- All of Allah's Guidance comes through communication.

"The human being's ability to receive guidance spiritually, emotionally, intellectually, could never have happened if he wasn't capable of clear speech."

الرَّحْمَنُ ﴿١﴾ عَلَّمَ الْقُرْآنَ ﴿٢﴾ خَلَقَ الْإِنْسَانَ ﴿٣﴾ عَلَّمَهُ الْبَيَانَ ٤ - The Most Merciful taught the Quran, created mankind, taught him clarity of speech (55:1-3)

- Allah created Adam (PBUH): « He taught Adam (PBUH) the names of all things ». That was the beginning of our story, the beginning of guidance. And what was the final guidance? Quran itself, which is *البيان*.

Argument #1:

What began with Adam (PBUH) reached its climax with the coming of the Quran. It's as though Allah gave us the gift of speech so that one day we could be worthy of the Quran.

- About language itself, he says:

“ Speech can never be understood unless you recognize that its components have been organized. How parts of it correspond to other parts of it. It’s impossible to understand somebody if one thing they say is disconnected from the next thing. If you take only one part of the speech, you can’t get the point, you are going to be missing the meaning.”

Argument #2:

- If that becomes your view of the Quran, taking three ayat without considering the hundreds of other ayat in the same surah, your understanding will be incomplete.
- In our speech, if we take things out of context, we won’t be able to understand it since it is part of a whole speech.
- The word “Quran” has two origins. One is “that which is read” قَرَأَ, while the other is قَرَنَ, which means « to flow »
- So the Quran has a flow, and you can’t have a flow by dropping one line only, it has to have one line after another, after another to create the flow.

Farahi’s Response to his Critics

In the late 1800’s, Dr. Hamiduddin Farahi advised his students to ponder over the Quran, to look at the surah holistically. His fellow scholars who taught fiqh, aqeedah, hadith and other religious sciences were annoyed with him and his students. They would ask: “Why are you wasting so much time contemplating the order of the ayat?”

Ustadh Nouman translates Farahi’s response to his critics:

“The most harmful thing is that people are just completely oblivious of this knowledge (coherence, structure, holistic view of the Quran). It’s because it’s so hard and so not obvious, and there are so many possible ways for you to slip up and figure out what is going on in a surah, this can’t possibly be one of the fundamental things to do in the religion. It can only be an extracurricular activity, looking for the coherence of the speech and analyzing the beauty and eloquence and rhetoric, it is just a waste of time. And who would dare consider that as a fundamental exercise of the religion, and on top of that encourage students to be involved in this kind of inquiry. This kind of person is preventing them from doing the mandatory things in Islam. This is a deviation, he is changing the religion, and he is corrupting the education system. And I have heard this kind of criticism even from those who acknowledge finding the Quran’s coherence, finding that the ayat are connected. They say to me « Quran came so you can act on it. It came so you can get guidance from its light, not try to find these subtleties, these connections and to look at words, why are you busying yourself with that?». ”

The subtleties of the Quran and observing its coherence are not the goal at all, you won’t achieve success with it. Those observations are a by-product of something far more important.

The ultimate goal is contemplating the words of Allah, which have deliberately been placed in a context.

That contemplation and looking at the Book as a whole is the only way by which we can properly reflect upon the Quran. Do you really think you don't need to contemplate Allah's words? And you don't have any need for what Allah revealed to you?

This entire endeavour is a spiritual exercise, it is تَدَبُّر over the Quran. Do you think that the books of fiqh have already extracted everything in Allah's Book, so there is no reason for us to contemplate Quran anymore? It is only used to look for دليل for the فُتْوَى?

The Quran would then only be read to look for proof (دليل) and to gain reward (أجر): If we only focus on halal and haram, then we only read it for ajr."

- Then he continues:

"Isn't it true that the outward good we do (haj, zakat, eating halal...) is directly tied to beliefs and intentions? To something inwardly? Both of those things are directly tied to our mannerism, to our character. Isn't it true that when a person is reformed, that is the only way of society to be reformed? Don't you realize that a person can never be reformed until they go to the very essence of wisdom? Nobody can become a better person by learning what is halal or haram. Nobody can deeply be connected to Allah by knowing which group was deviant in which way. How are you connected to the inner wisdom of your faith?

The inner change can only come from the words of Allah, from the Quran. If we were naturally spiritually sound people, then we wouldn't need to go back to the original source. But when corruption and mischief dominate society, and then beliefs are all over the place, and the hearts are sleeping, and the harmony and order of religion has been depleted and the sharia has lost its uprightness, and the cultural, economical and political authorities are making up new things about the religion, while we are following them, our need for divine wisdom becomes more and more intense (...). We have to find a way out of the trial and tribulation of the religion being torn apart (...).

Who's holding onto Quran? Who is bringing people together? When the roads become confusing, and everyone who has their own opinion is really impressed by it, and ignorance has already caused great famine in society and seeking guidance from the Quran is refused. The same Quran that Allah Himself describes as light and healing, do you feel that you are not in need of Allah's wisdom? Do you think it can come without reflection? (...). If it wasn't the case that we had to stop, reflect and dive into the Book, how could Allah commanded us to do تدبر of the Quran and think deeply about His ayat? And if there weren't any things to discover, if everything was just on the surface, why do we have to contemplate?"

- تَدَبُّر comes from the word دَبَّر: which means « the back ». How do you find what is behind these words? This is the surface of the word and behind them there is a wisdom, a meaning, a guidance that applies to people and opens up hearts and minds.
- The form of the word used for taddabur is تَفَعَّل, which implies making a huge effort. So putting the word دَبَّر in the تَفَعَّل form in order to get the word تَدَبُّر indicates that you are striving to understand what is behind these words, to dive into each word.
- Farahi's spiritual argument is:

"Why don't you take a good look at everything above you, around you, under you, all of the things that Allah has created. Forget about pondering Quran, ponder everything else. You will find two things: everything is organized, compiled one on top of the other so that you can benefit from it and enjoy its beauty. Look at a single leaf and find the symmetrical veins on it, zoom in and look at a single ice crystal, look at the pattern inside a flower, look at what honey bees do, just look at all of creation. Observe the beauty of the design of the heart, the way which a baby is formed, you will find remarkable method, symmetry, system and order. Everything is in order. Order has everything to do with the way it produces benefit and the way it makes it beautiful"

- Quran has two things that soften the heart: its benefit مَنَافِع and its beauty مَحَاسِن. When you see something beautiful your heart softens (a beautiful baby, a beautiful mountain...). These two elements are the keys to تَدَبُّر:

"You can even see that order, sequence, is the essence of the existence of all things around us."

- There is an arrangement that Allah puts even inside of our bodies our fingers, the position of our eyes etc.

"Get rid of the order, and there is nothing left. That is why craftiness, artistry, beauty and its perfection can never exist without the existence of order. A maker, designer, a manufacture will only be praised in accordance to the perfection that they brought to their sequence, how they ordered things. Or it could be they are criticized for the weakness of order and harmony in their work."

"Everything you do is either a success or failure depending on how organized it was." If you want results order will always be a prerequisite, whether it's sports, business, studies. For example, if you want to get more fit you will have to discipline your diet.

"This is a deep truth that anyone who possesses a thinking mind can never deny. If all of this make sense to you, why don't you turn your intentions to the subject of order and harmony when it comes to speech itself. Speech is essentially something that is composed of one part put on top of another, put on top of another... in a certain order. It can't have a meaning without an order. If you mess up the order, it doesn't have a meaning anymore."

- The gift of language depends on its order. The word used in the Quran to refer to the ordered use of language is بَيَان
- بَيَان comes from بَانَ - يَبِينُ which means to « separate things ».
- Organization is necessary for communication. The more organized a speech is, the more you understand it, if a speech is all over the place, you can't understand it.
- The more unorganized a person's thoughts are, the more unintelligent he is assumed to be.
- Part of the beauty and power of speech is how a point is made, how it is organized. Order is everything. That is how a single word would make sense, and words put together in a certain order only then can make a sentence and if you change it, the meaning would be different.

Farahi concludes:

"If order is so important in human communication, then how dare you say the speech of Allah is not heavenly ordered?"

- The One who put order to all things, will not put order in His Book while he even put order in your fingertips?
- How can we deny heavenly order? It's Allah's word! Everything He does is in balance and harmony.